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EFL University student perceptions and experiences of learning to speak through a drama as a pedagogical tool: opportunities and challenges

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Abstract

Speaking is widely regarded as one of the most challenging skills for EFL learners, shaped by linguistic, affective, and pedagogical factors. Although drama-based pedagogy can foster authentic interaction, its use in Indonesian higher education remains limited. This qualitative case study investigated Indonesian university students' perceptions of drama-based speaking activities following a semester of structured drama instruction. Data from ten group interviews with 30 students, including six focal participants analyzed in depth, were examined using iterative thematic analysis. Findings reveal that while students valued role-plays, improvisation, and storytelling as opportunities for authentic communication, these benefits were constrained by psychological barriers, limited opportunities for interaction, performance-oriented assessment, and entrenched teaching practices. Students also voiced aspirations for more learner-centered and supportive pedagogies. The study concludes that drama's affordances are not automatic but require thoughtful task design, teacher mediation, and formative assessment, offering insights into how drama can bridge linguistic and socio-affective dimensions of EFL speaking instruction.

Keywords: Communicative competence, Drama pedagogy, EFL university students, Speaking instruction

Introduction

Speaking has long been recognized as the most demanding and complex skill in second language learning because it requires learners to integrate grammar, vocabulary, fluency, and interactional awareness in real time (Bygate, 2009; Yan et al., 2024). Unlike receptive skills such as reading or listening, speaking unfolds through spontaneous interaction with limited opportunities for planning, monitoring, or correction, making it particularly fragile in English as a foreign language (EFL) contexts (Dan et al., 2026; Richards, 2008). For this reason, speaking competence is often considered the ultimate benchmark of communicative ability (Tavakoli et al., 2020). Yet, despite decades of curricular reforms promoting communicative

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language teaching (CLT), a persistent gap remains between communicative ideals and classroom realities in many educational systems (Han, 2022).

Globally, research indicates that learners frequently complete years of formal instruction with limited ability to use English meaningfully beyond the classroom (Xuan Mai et al., 2024). In East Asia, oral proficiency is often constrained by instructional practices emphasizing accuracy, memorization, and exam preparation at the expense of authentic interaction (Butler, 2015; Zhong et al., 2025). In Latin America, communicative curricula are commonly undermined by scripted dialogues and rehearsed presentations that restrict spontaneous language use (Galante & Thomson, 2017). Even in Europe, where CLIL (Content and Language Integrated Learning) is widely implemented, teachers continue to struggle with balancing linguistic accuracy and interactional adaptability (Villabona & Cenoz, 2021). These recurring patterns suggest that difficulties in developing speaking competence are not merely local or individual but systemic, reflecting tensions between institutional demands, assessment regimes, and pedagogical ideals.

In Indonesia, these tensions are especially pronounced. Although English is taught from secondary school through university, many students graduate with limited oral proficiency and low communicative confidence (Zein et al., 2020). Empirical studies consistently report that Indonesian EFL classrooms remain dominated by teacher-centered practices, rigid syllabi, and assessment systems prioritizing grammatical accuracy over communicative use (Hanifa et al., 2024). Speaking instruction is often reduced to grammar drills, memorized dialogues, and scripted presentations (Burns, 2016). While such practices may reinforce linguistic correctness, they do little to prepare learners for the unpredictability, negotiation of meaning, and sociopragmatic demands of real-life communication.

The consequences are not only linguistic but also affective. Indonesian EFL learners frequently report high levels of anxiety, fear of negative evaluation, and reluctance to speak in front of peers (Abdurahman & Rizqi, 2021). Many rely heavily on memorization because they feel unprepared to improvise or respond spontaneously. From a sociocognitive perspective, these difficulties cannot be attributed solely to learners' individual limitations; rather, they are shaped by broader ecological conditions such as hierarchical teacher–student relations, exam-driven cultures, and classroom norms that privilege correctness over collaboration (Atkinson, 2011; Mercer, 2019). These conditions limit learners' opportunities to experiment with language, negotiate identity, and develop confidence as communicators.

Within this context, there is a growing need for pedagogical approaches that move beyond form-focused, teacher-centered instruction and instead provide learners with meaningful, low-risk spaces for interaction, experimentation, and self-expression. Drama-based pedagogy offers such a possibility. Drama activities such as role-play, improvisation, and performance situate language use in embodied, socially meaningful contexts where learners can explore perspectives, collaborate with peers, and engage emotionally as well as cognitively (Kao et al., 2011a, 2011b; Schonmann, 2011). By shifting the focus from accuracy to meaning-making, drama-based pedagogy reduces affective barriers, encourages risk-taking, and fosters communicative confidence (Galante & Thomson, 2017; Gregersen & Horwitz, 2002). Empirical studies across

diverse contexts show that drama can enhance fluency, lexical range, motivation, empathy, and learner engagement (Hwang et al., 2024; Jusslin et al., 2022).

In Indonesia, emerging studies suggest that drama-based approaches can improve students' confidence and reduce speaking anxiety at the secondary level (Sarem et al., 2018), while drama-informed digital storytelling projects promote autonomy and creative expression in higher education (Peñalba et al., 2020). However, despite these promising findings, drama remains marginal in Indonesian EFL classrooms, often sidelined by exam-oriented curricula and rigid pedagogical structures (Puspitasari, 2024). More broadly, learner-centered and identity-affirming pedagogies such as intercultural, reflective, and drama-based approaches are frequently treated as peripheral rather than integral to language learning (Munandara & Newton, 2021; Sari, 2022). These studies demonstrate that when learners engage in creative, experiential, and reflective tasks, they do not merely practice language forms but actively negotiate meaning, identity, and intercultural awareness processes that align closely with the core principles of drama-based pedagogy.

Despite the growing body of research on drama in language education (Arda Tuncdemir, 2025; Kao et al., 2011a, 2011b; Stinson & Winston, 2011), one critical dimension remains underexplored: students' voices. Much of the existing literature focuses on teachers' instructional strategies, curricular design, or measurable learning outcomes, while paying limited attention to how learners themselves experience both the challenges of speaking and the opportunities afforded by drama-based learning. This gap is significant because affective and subjective factors such as confidence, anxiety, enjoyment, and willingness to take risks play a decisive role in communicative development (Jusslin et al., 2022). Without incorporating learners' perspectives, pedagogical innovations risk being theoretically sound but ecologically misaligned with students' lived experiences.

To address this gap, the present study foregrounds Indonesian EFL university students' perceptions and experiences of learning to speak through drama-based pedagogy. It conceptualizes speaking as socially situated, emergent, and deeply shaped by affective and relational factors. Specifically, the study explores two research questions: (1) How do students perceive drama-based performance as a tool for enhancing speaking competence? and (2) What challenges do they encounter in drama-based speaking activities? By centering learners' voices, this study contributes to a more nuanced understanding of how creative pedagogy can support communicative development in exam-driven EFL contexts (Widodo et al., 2016). The findings aim to inform contextually grounded, learner-centered pedagogies that balance linguistic development, emotional engagement, and the sociocognitive demands of real-world communication.

Communicative competence and challenges in EFL speaking

Communicative competence has been conceptualized in multiple and sometimes contested ways in the literature (Xi, 2025). Early formulations by Widdowson (1989) challenged purely structural views of language, arguing that knowing a language entails not only grammatical accuracy but also the ability to use it meaningfully and appropriately in context. Canale and Swain's (1980) influential framework further operationalized this idea by proposing four interrelated components: grammatical,

sociolinguistic, discourse, and strategic competence. While this model broadened the scope of what it means to “know” a language, it has also been critiqued for implicitly privileging cognitive and linguistic dimensions over social, embodied, and relational aspects of communication. More recently, Brunner (2022) has expanded the construct to include intercultural and interactional dimensions, emphasizing that communication is not merely the transmission of information but an ongoing process of negotiating meaning, managing identities, and navigating sociocultural norms. This shift reflects a growing recognition that communicative competence is not a fixed set of skills but an emergent, socially situated practice.

In EFL contexts, communicative competence is widely regarded as a central goal, with speaking often treated as its most visible and measurable manifestation (Ramdani & Rahmat, 2018; Richards, 2008). Speaking is commonly associated with academic participation, global mobility, and employability, which reinforces its perceived instrumental value. However, this emphasis also risks reducing speaking to a functional or performative skill, rather than understanding it as a complex, affectively charged, and socially embedded practice. Despite decades of communicative-oriented reforms, speaking instruction in many EFL settings including Indonesia remains limited in its effectiveness (Canale, 1983; Ramdani & Rahmat, 2018). This raises a critical question: if communicative competence is so highly valued, why do classroom practices continue to fall short of supporting its development?

Existing research points to several interrelated constraints (Zheng et al., 2024). Affective variables, particularly foreign language anxiety, play a powerful role in inhibiting oral participation, with learners frequently reporting fear of negative evaluation, embarrassment, and reluctance to speak (Banegas et al., 2020; Gregersen & Horwitz, 2002). Yet anxiety is often treated as an individual psychological problem, rather than as a socially produced response to classroom norms, power relations, and assessment cultures. At the same time, institutional and pedagogical structures frequently privilege grammatical accuracy and written testing, leaving little space for authentic, spontaneous interaction (Richards, 2008). Speaking tasks are commonly reduced to scripted dialogues or rehearsed presentations, which may simulate communication but rarely reflect its unpredictability or relational nature. This reveals a deeper contradiction: while communicative competence is promoted discursively, classroom practices often reproduce form-focused, risk-averse learning environments.

In Indonesia, these tensions are particularly evident in higher education. Studies document high levels of speaking anxiety, hesitation, and difficulty generating ideas during oral tasks (Hanifa, 2018). Students typically have limited exposure to English outside the classroom, and assessment practices often emphasize pronunciation accuracy or grammatical correctness rather than interactional fluency or meaning negotiation. Ironically, although speaking is frequently identified by students as the most valuable skill, it remains the least effectively developed. This suggests that the problem is not merely one of learner motivation or ability, but of systemic misalignment between pedagogical goals, instructional practices, and learners’ communicative realities.

While previous research has been valuable in identifying obstacles to speaking development, much of it relies on quantitative measures of proficiency or anxiety, offering limited insight into how learners actually experience speaking instruction

(Okyar, 2023). This emphasis on outcomes over experiences risks oversimplifying complex classroom dynamics and obscuring learners' voices. Without understanding how students interpret, negotiate, and emotionally respond to speaking tasks, pedagogical interventions may remain theoretically sound but practically ineffective. A more critical and learner-centered perspective is therefore needed that treats students not merely as recipients of instruction but as active meaning-makers within specific sociocultural ecologies. This gap opens space for exploring alternative pedagogies, such as drama-based approaches, which foreground embodiment, imagination, collaboration, and emotional engagement. Such approaches may not only enhance linguistic performance but also reconfigure the affective and relational conditions under which speaking occurs. By examining learners' lived experiences of these practices, researchers can better understand how communicative competence is actually formed, resisted, or transformed in real classrooms.

Drama performance in EFL speaking instruction

Drama-based learning is commonly conceptualized as the pedagogical use of role play, process drama, and performance tasks to simulate authentic communicative situations in the classroom (Lee & Liu, 2022). Rooted in sociocultural theory (Vygotsky, 1978), drama is often framed as a collaborative space where learners co-construct meaning and practice language within their zone of proximal development. From a communicative language teaching (CLT) perspective, drama is valued for generating meaningful interaction that requires learners to mobilize linguistic resources while negotiating roles, intentions, and identities (Nguyen, 2023). However, this framing tends to idealize drama as inherently "authentic" and "communicative," overlooking the fact that authenticity is not a given but socially and pedagogically constructed. Without careful design and mediation, drama activities can easily reproduce the same performance pressures, power hierarchies, and form-focused norms that constrain conventional speaking tasks. Thus, while drama holds particular promise for EFL contexts marked by anxiety, low confidence, and limited exposure to real-world interaction, its effectiveness cannot be assumed; it must be critically examined in relation to how learners actually experience it.

Speaking through drama is not a linear acquisition process but an emergent, mediated, and relational one shaped by teacher support, peer interaction, and classroom norms. Drawing on experiential learning theory (Kolb, 1984), drama situates learners in cycles of experience, reflection, conceptualization, and reapplication, rendering speaking practice embodied rather than purely cognitive. Yet, experiential engagement alone does not guarantee communicative development. Learners may encounter heightened performance anxiety, lexical constraints, or difficulty improvising, especially in cultures where public speaking is associated with evaluation rather than exploration. Without intentional scaffolding through guided rehearsal, structured feedback, and reflective dialogue drama risks becoming an emotionally demanding performance rather than a supportive learning space (Goh, 2017). This tension highlights the need to move beyond celebratory accounts of drama and instead interrogate how its pedagogical conditions shape learner participation.

Although existing research (Nguyen, 2023) suggests that drama can enhance vocabulary retention, fluency, and willingness to communicate, much of this work

privileges measurable outcomes over lived experiences. Such an emphasis risks instrumentalizing drama as merely another technique for boosting performance scores, rather than understanding it as a complex social practice. Qualitative approaches are therefore essential for examining how identity negotiation, emotional involvement, peer dynamics, and mediation shape speaking development over time (Fisher et al., 2018). From a sociocognitive perspective, speaking is not simply a matter of individual competence but a situated activity requiring adaptability, empathy, and collaborative problem-solving. For instance, Nguyen (2023) found that drama enabled Vietnamese EFL learners to manage turn-taking and adapt language use to interactional demands, while Bora (2020) reported increased spontaneity and communicative confidence through process drama. However, these findings also raise questions about whose voices are represented and how learners themselves interpret these changes—an issue that remains underexplored.

Despite its reported benefits, drama remains marginal in mainstream undergraduate EFL curricula, where instruction continues to prioritize accuracy, drills, scripted dialogues, and rehearsed presentations (Nguyen, 2023). Such practices reflect deeper institutional logics that privilege control, predictability, and assessment efficiency over exploration, uncertainty, and identity work. As a result, drama is often treated as an enrichment activity rather than a legitimate mode of communicative development. This marginalization contributes to a significant gap in the literature: little is known about how Indonesian university students themselves perceive drama-based learning as a pathway to speaking competence. To address this gap, the present study explores two research questions: (1) How do students perceive drama performance as a means of developing their speaking skills? and (2) What challenges constrain Indonesian EFL students' communicative competence in drama-based speaking?

Examining how students perceive drama performance as a means of developing speaking skills is crucial because communicative competence is not merely a technical outcome but a lived, affective, and socially situated experience. Learners' interpretations shape their willingness to participate, take risks, and engage meaningfully, thereby directly influencing development. At the same time, identifying the challenges that constrain Indonesian EFL students' participation in drama-based speaking is essential for avoiding idealized assumptions about its effectiveness. Institutional norms, anxiety, linguistic limitations, and cultural expectations may mediate or even inhibit its potential. Together, these questions enable a context-sensitive understanding of how speaking competence is actually formed, negotiated, and constrained in real classrooms.

Student voices in drama-based EFL learning

Student voices refer to learners' perspectives, reflections, and lived experiences of classroom participation. In language education, attending to student voices enables researchers to move beyond surface-level outcomes and examine how learners interpret instructional practices, negotiate meaning, and make sense of their own progress (Canals, 2022). This perspective is particularly important in drama-based EFL instruction, where learning is not merely cognitive but embodied, relational, and identity-laden. Drama requires learners to adopt roles, engage emotionally, and perform

collaboratively, all of which are deeply entangled with confidence, motivation, and willingness to take communicative risks. Unlike traditional instruction where learners' experiences are often reduced to test scores or proficiency gains drama foregrounds how language learning is lived, negotiated, and emotionally experienced in situ.

However, integrating student voices into drama-based pedagogy is neither straightforward nor unproblematic. Many EFL learners experience anxiety, fear of making mistakes, and discomfort with public performance (Chen & Hwang, 2020). These affective constraints are intensified in many Asian contexts, where classroom cultures emphasize accuracy, examination success, and teacher authority, often limiting opportunities for self-expression and experimentation. As a result, drama can be simultaneously empowering and threatening; while some learners experience increased agency through role enactment and creative expression, others remain constrained by linguistic insecurity and social apprehension (Aladini & Jalambo, 2021). This tension suggests that drama should not be uncritically celebrated as liberating, but examined in terms of how learners actually experience it.

Empirical studies illustrate this complexity. Ngo and Nguyen (2024) found that Vietnamese EFL students valued collaborative drama as a space for expressing linguistic and cultural identities, even while struggling with improvisation. Similarly, Galante and Thomson (2017) reported that students' perceptions shaped their engagement: those who found drama meaningful demonstrated greater motivation and willingness to communicate, whereas those who associated it with anxiety were more likely to withdraw. Ng (2021) likewise observed that Japanese students continued to experience performance-related nervousness despite drama's potential for authentic interaction. Collectively, these findings underscore that student voices reveal not only linguistic development but also the socioaffective dimensions of learning that often remain invisible in outcome-based research.

Yet, much of the existing literature privileges measurable gains, such as fluency, vocabulary growth, or intercultural competence over learners' subjective evaluations of their experiences (Khau & Huynh, 2022; Patra et al., 2022). While such studies demonstrate effectiveness, they rarely interrogate whether students experience drama as empowering, intimidating, or pedagogically meaningful. This represents a significant gap, particularly in Indonesian higher education, where speaking instruction remains dominated by scripted dialogues, memorization, and exam-oriented practices.

Foregrounding student voices is therefore not merely complementary but essential for evaluating drama's pedagogical value. Learners' perspectives illuminate how constraints such as anxiety, linguistic limitations, and cultural expectations shape participation, while also revealing possibilities for confidence-building, collaboration, and identity exploration. Accordingly, the present study investigates how Indonesian EFL students perceive drama performance as a pathway to communicative competence, focusing on both the challenges they encounter and the meanings they attach to drama in their language learning trajectories.

Methodology

Research orientation

We employed a qualitative case study design within an interpretive paradigm, aiming to understand how students experienced and made sense of drama-based speaking instruction, rather than to measure variables or establish causal relationships between instructional practices and learning outcomes. Unlike survey research, which typically seeks to identify patterns across large samples through standardized instruments, our approach prioritizes depth, context, and meaning-making. The interpretive paradigm enabled us to engage closely with students' narratives, conceptualizing communicative competence not as a fixed attribute but as a lived, socially and culturally situated practice shaped by emotions, institutional norms, and classroom interactions.

We occupied a partial insider position, as one of us served as a lecturer at one of the participating universities but did not teach the observed classes. This positionality afforded privileged access to institutional routines, classroom cultures, and interactional dynamics, while also requiring sustained reflexivity. We maintained analytical distance through reflective memos that documented methodological decisions, emerging interpretations, and potential biases. These practices enhanced the transparency, credibility, and critical grounding of our analysis.

We frame this study as a case study because it investigates a *bounded instructional phenomenon* rather than a population. The "case" is defined as the implementation of drama-based speaking practices mediated by the SCoDA framework within three undergraduate English education programs operating under comparable curricular and institutional conditions. Our unit of analysis is not individual students' opinions in isolation, as would be typical in a survey, but the situated enactment of drama-based pedagogy as it unfolds within a specific educational ecology. Students' accounts are therefore treated as *embedded perspectives* that illuminate different dimensions of the same case, rather than as independent data points intended for aggregation or statistical generalization.

Unlike survey research, which aggregates responses to produce decontextualized trends, our case study approach seeks to generate a thick, contextualized understanding of how drama-based instruction is experienced, negotiated, and constrained in practice. Our aim is not representativeness but analytic depth: to reveal how institutional norms, affective dynamics, and pedagogical mediation shape students' communicative development within a particular setting. This orientation allows us to offer theoretically and pedagogically meaningful insights that may be transferable to similar EFL contexts, rather than statistically generalizable claims.

Context of the study

The study was conducted in three undergraduate English education programs at Indonesian universities, where speaking courses are compulsory during the first two years. Although national curricula emphasize communicative competence, instruction remains predominantly accuracy-oriented, with lessons relying on memorized dialogues and scripted performances that prioritize grammatical correctness and pronunciation over interactional responsiveness. Teachers typically lead from the front, while students assume the role of performers rather than interlocutors, which limits opportunities

for spontaneous, meaning-driven communication. This conservatism reflects broader systemic tensions: assessments emphasize correctness, syllabi leave little space for pedagogical experimentation, and hierarchical teacher–student relations encourage linguistic caution. As a result, many learners develop neither the confidence nor the interactional awareness necessary for genuine communicative competence that Littlewood (2014) describes as the “implementation gap.”

Against this backdrop, lecturers introduced drama-based activities not as an extracurricular supplement but as a structured component of regular speaking courses. These activities included role-plays, improvisation, storytelling, and short group performances. To organize these practices, we drew on what we term the Socio-Cognitive Drama-Based Approach (SCoDA), which structured classroom activity into three interrelated phases: preparation (scenario building, vocabulary activation, role allocation), enactment (collaborative performance), and reflection (feedback on language use, communicative strategies, and affective responses). Importantly, these activities were embedded within existing curricular constraints rather than implemented as a controlled or standardized treatment. Their purpose was not to replace conventional instruction but to mediate students’ movement from controlled to more spontaneous speaking while foregrounding sociocognitive dimensions such as confidence, empathy, collaboration, and reflective awareness.

Crucially, in this study, SCoDA is not positioned as an intervention whose effectiveness is tested or compared against other pedagogical approaches. Instead, we conceptualize it as a pedagogical mediation framework that organizes how drama-based practices are designed, enacted, and interpreted within real classroom conditions. The framework integrates three complementary theoretical traditions, such as sociocognitive theory, experiential learning, and communicative competence not as a hierarchical synthesis but as a juxtaposition that foregrounds different dimensions of speaking development.

Sociocognitive theory informs our understanding of learning as emerging through interaction, affect, and participation, emphasizing that cognition is inseparable from social engagement and emotional positioning. Experiential learning frames drama activities as iterative cycles of action and reflection, allowing learners to experiment with language, encounter difficulty, and reconfigure understanding through experience. Communicative competence provides the lens for examining speaking beyond formal accuracy, encompassing fluency, pragmatic appropriateness, interactional responsiveness, and strategic adaptation. Rather than merging these theories into a single unified construct, SCoDA places them in dialogue to conceptualize speaking as a situated, embodied, and socially mediated practice.



Fig. 1 SCoDa drama pedagogy cycle

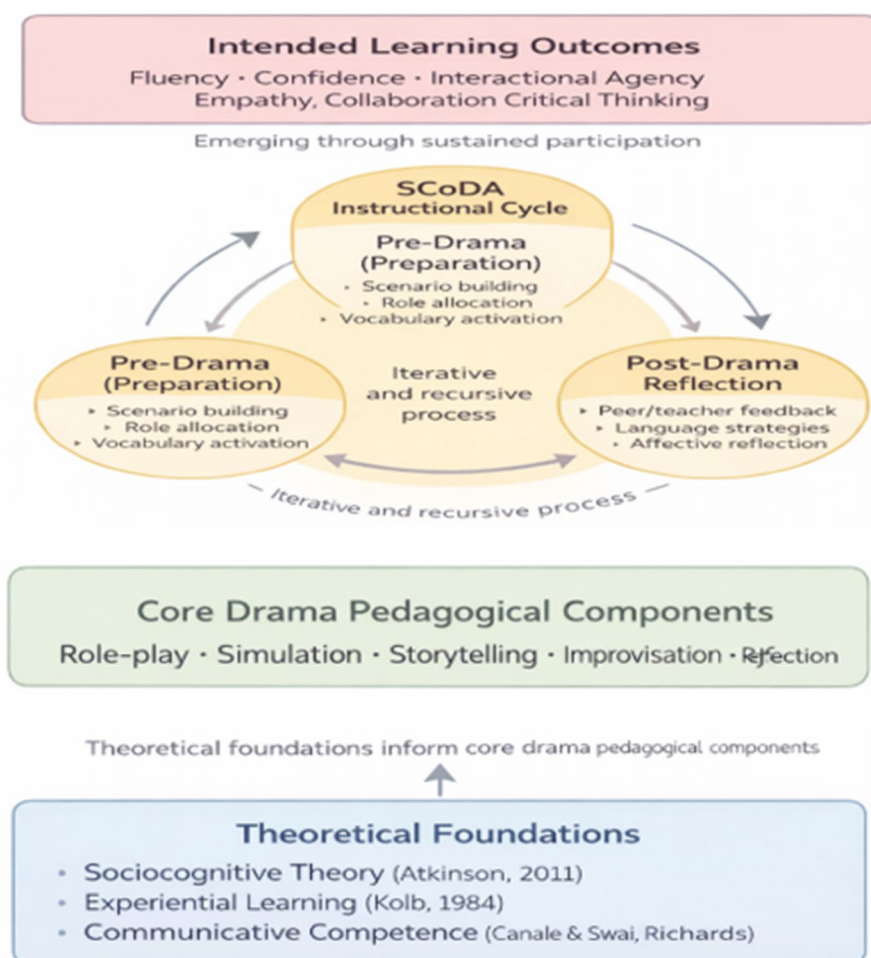


Fig. 2 Framework diagram of the SCoDA model

Figures 1 and 2 visualize this framework as layered and process-oriented rather than linear or prescriptive. The instructional cycle such as pre-drama preparation, drama enactment, and post-drama reflection does not represent a standardized treatment whose effects are measured. Instead, it serves as an analytic scaffold for examining how learners experienced, interpreted, and negotiated drama-based speaking practices across different phases of classroom activity. The model's purpose is therefore descriptive and interpretive, not experimental.

Importantly, the enactment of SCoDA varied across classes and sessions, reflecting institutional constraints, teacher beliefs, time limitations, and curricular demands. While drama-based activities emphasized role allocation, scenario building, improvisation, collaborative storytelling, and reflective dialogue, these elements were not uniformly implemented. In some classes, drama remained episodic or peripheral rather than central to course design. We therefore do not claim to evaluate the effectiveness or impact of SCoDA as a pedagogical intervention. Nor do we make causal claims about its influence on language development. Instead, we use SCoDA as an analytic lens to interpret students' perceptions, affective responses, and participatory experiences as they moved through preparation, enactment, and reflection phases. This allows us to

examine how drama-based speaking is experienced under real classroom conditions and how its potential is shaped—and often constrained—by institutional structures, cultural norms, and affective dynamics. We acknowledge that this design does not provide empirical evidence of SCoDA's instructional effectiveness. Rather than positioning the model as a validated intervention, we present it as a theoretically grounded framework for understanding how drama-based practices are mediated, experienced, and negotiated in context.

Participants

Thirty undergraduate students (aged 19–21) from three English education programs at Indonesian universities participated in the study (see Table 1). All were enrolled in mid-level speaking courses (e.g., Speaking for Communication, Academic Listening and Speaking), which typically emphasize structured presentations, scripted dialogues, and controlled language practice. Although most participants could deliver rehearsed

Table 1 Demographic profiles of participants

Participants initial	Code	Gender	Proficiency level	Drama experience	Willingness to communicate (WTC)
FA	S1	Female	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
R	S2	Female	Lower-intermediate	Limited	Low
SM	S3	Female	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
KA	S4	Female	Lower-intermediate	Limited	Low
MR	S5	Female	Intermediate	Moderate	Medium
FR	S6	Female	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
NL	S7	Female	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
Z	S8	Female	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
J	S9	Male	Intermediate	Moderate	Medium
HN	S10	Male	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
G	S11	Female	Lower-intermediate	None	Low
SA	S12	Female	Lower-intermediate	None	Low
D	S13	Male	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
K	S14	Female	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
L	S15	Female	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
P	S16	Female	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
N	S17	Male	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
SN	S18	Female	Lower-intermediate	None	Low
DR	S19	Female	Lower-intermediate	None	Low
LN	S20	Female	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
NR	S21	Male	Intermediate	None	High
O	S22	Female	Lower-intermediate	None	Low
I	S23	Male	Lower-intermediate	None	Low
AP	S24	Female	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
NM	S25	Male	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
P	S26	Female	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
L	S27	Male	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
TF	S28	Female	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
D	S29	Female	Intermediate	Limited	Medium
AS	S30	Male	Intermediate	Limited	Medium

speeches, many struggled with spontaneous interaction, lexical retrieval, and anxiety management. None had received systematic drama-based instruction prior to the study.

Ethical clearance was obtained from all participating institutions prior to the study. Students were fully informed about the purpose, procedures, and potential risks of the research, and their participation was entirely voluntary. They were assured that their responses would remain confidential and would not affect their academic standing. To protect participants' identities, pseudonyms were used consistently in all data reporting and analysis.

Data collection and analysis followed a two-stage qualitative design consistent with an embedded case study approach. In the first stage, we conducted semi-structured interviews with all 30 participants to construct a holistic understanding of the instructional context, shared challenges in speaking, and students' initial responses to drama-based activities. This stage was not intended to function as a comparative survey of individuals, but rather to generate a thematic map of the case capturing recurring experiences, constraints, and meanings associated with speaking instruction in these programs.

In the second stage, we purposively recruited six focal participants for in-depth analysis. This recruitment was guided by maximum variation sampling, with the aim of capturing contrasting learner profiles within the same instructional context. Three criteria informed selection: (1) English proficiency level, (2) willingness to communicate (WTC), and (3) degree of engagement in drama-based activities. Rather than treating these as fixed traits, we conceptualized them as situated and interactionally manifested orientations that could shift across activities and contexts.

English proficiency was determined through triangulation of institutional speaking assessment records, instructor evaluations, and observed classroom performance. Institutional assessments included mid-term and final oral examinations, which emphasized fluency, coherence, and comprehensibility. These records were corroborated through instructors' written evaluations and our own classroom observations of participants' ability to sustain spontaneous talk, retrieve vocabulary, and respond to peers during drama tasks.

Willingness to Communicate (WTC) was inferred through triangulated qualitative indicators rather than through a self-report scale. Specifically, we examined interview accounts of students' attitudes toward speaking, classroom observation notes, and participation patterns during drama-based activities. Observable indicators included frequency of voluntary turn-taking, initiation of interaction, responsiveness to peers, and persistence in communicative attempts despite errors. This triangulated approach allowed us to interpret WTC as a context-sensitive disposition rather than a stable personality trait (Table 2).

The six focal participants (three male, three female) were selected to represent contrasting configurations of these dimensions. For example, two participants demonstrated relatively higher proficiency but low WTC, often avoiding voluntary participation despite linguistic resources. Two others showed lower proficiency but high WTC, actively engaging in interaction despite frequent breakdowns. The remaining two occupied mid-range positions, with moderate proficiency and fluctuating WTC depending on task demands and peer dynamics. These contrasting profiles enabled us

Table 2 Interview excerpts highlighting psychological affective barriers

Participant	Code	Date	Response
KA (S4)	S4	Feb 2024	When teacher ask me a question, my mind suddenly blank. I actually know what to answer but my heart beat fast and I'm scared if I say wrong and my friends laugh. I feel better if I can memorize first, not suddenly speak
KA (S4)	S4	Feb 2024	Usually we just memorize the dialogue, so I feel safe. But when we must make our own sentences, I don't know what to say next. It's scary but new for me
MR (S5)	S5	Feb 2024	Speaking test feels not natural... like we are performing, not talking. We prepare like a speech and then teacher corrects our mistakes. Role-play is more fun, but not many times we do it
FR (S6)	S6	Feb 2024	Not much, because we always follow the script. I can say the lines, but in real conversation I cannot respond fast. I also worry about my accent. Sometimes I think it's weird and then I lose focus
I (S23)	S23	Feb 2024	Sometimes I know the idea, but I'm too nervous to speak. My heart beat fast, I forget words. And because not many spontaneous activities, I'm not used to it. I only feel better after some role-play, but it's not often
NR (S21)	S21	Feb 2024	I like speaking, but sometimes I stop because I don't have enough vocabulary. If we can choose our own topic, maybe I can speak more naturally. I also think video recording can help. If I can see myself, I can improve, not just get the score

Source: Authors' own work

to examine how students with different communicative orientations experienced and interpreted the same pedagogical conditions. This embedded design allowed us to move beyond generalized claims about “students” and instead trace how individual trajectories unfolded within a shared instructional ecology. While the first-stage analysis established common patterns of experience, the second-stage analysis foregrounded how these patterns were differentially negotiated by learners with distinct affective, linguistic, and interactional dispositions.

Across the larger group, interview analysis revealed layered speaking constraints: psychological (nervousness, fear of negative evaluation), social (discomfort interacting with unfamiliar peers), and linguistic (limited vocabulary, reliance on memorization). Students described teacher-fronted lessons, performance-oriented assessment, and minimal formative feedback. Many expressed a desire for more spontaneous interaction, peer collaboration, topic flexibility, and reflective feedback—conditions they associated with drama-based activities.

From this group, the six focal participants were selected to enable a deeper, more nuanced analysis of how these shared challenges were experienced differently depending on proficiency, WTC, and engagement. These participants are treated in the Findings not as illustrative examples but as analytically central cases through which the complexity, tensions, and variability of drama-based speaking experiences are examined.

Data collection

Semi-structured group interviews constituted the primary data source, offering in-depth insight into students' perceptions of speaking instruction and their experiences with drama-based activities. A total of ten group interviews were conducted with all 30 participants, each comprising three to five students. The interviews lasted between 40 and 60 min, yielding approximately 8 h of recorded data in total. Group interviews were chosen to encourage peer interaction, co-construction of meaning, and collective reflection, as students often felt more at ease expressing their views in the presence

of classmates. All interviews were conducted toward the end of the semester, after students had participated in a series of structured drama-based activities such as role-plays, improvisation tasks, and short group performances integrated into their regular speaking courses. The sessions took place in quiet seminar rooms or unused classrooms on each university campus, ensuring a familiar, non-threatening, and interruption-free environment.

Access followed formal institutional procedures. As an insider lecturer at one of the participating universities, the researcher first contacted colleagues to introduce the study and seek their support, which facilitated communication with the Heads of the English Education Programs. After formal approval was granted, course lecturers assisted in coordinating interview schedules and introduced the researcher to students. Prior to participation, all students were informed about the purpose of the study, the voluntary nature of their involvement, their right to withdraw at any time, and the measures taken to ensure confidentiality. Written informed consent was obtained, and pseudonyms were used in all transcripts and reports.

The interview protocol addressed two main domains: (1) students' experiences and challenges in conventional speaking instruction, and (2) their perceptions of drama-based speaking activities. Participants were invited to reflect on psychological, linguistic, and interactional barriers, classroom practices, assessment orientations, and their expectations for more meaningful speaking tasks. In relation to drama, they discussed its influence on their confidence, motivation, willingness to communicate, peer interaction, and perceived communicative competence.

Interviews were conducted primarily in English; however, participants were allowed to code-switch into Indonesian when they felt unable to articulate complex emotions or ideas in English. This flexible language policy aimed to reduce anxiety and enable more nuanced expression. All sessions were video-recorded with participants' permission in order to capture both verbal and non-verbal interactional cues. The researcher adopted a facilitator role, prompting discussion while minimizing hierarchical influence. Field notes were taken immediately after each session to document interactional dynamics, notable affective responses, and emerging analytic insights. From the full cohort, six focal participants were purposively selected for in-depth analysis based on their proficiency levels, willingness to communicate, and degree of engagement in drama-based activities. Ethical clearance was obtained from all participating institutions prior to data collection.

Data analysis

Interview data were analyzed thematically to identify recurring patterns in students' perceptions of drama-based speaking instruction and the challenges they encountered. The analysis followed an iterative, multi-stage process informed by Sabbadin et al. (1998) thematic analysis framework and the constant comparative method (Boeije, 2002), enabling both within-case and cross-case comparison. A narrative analytic orientation (Huber et al., 2016) was adopted, allowing students' voices to be foregrounded while being critically interpreted in relation to existing literature. This approach facilitated the examination of tensions between pedagogical ideals and classroom realities.

Data familiarization involved repeated viewing of video recordings and multiple readings of interview transcripts alongside field notes. Attention was paid not only to semantic content but also to paralinguistic features such as pauses, laughter, hesitations, and changes in tone, which were treated as indicators of affective and interactional meaning. During this phase, preliminary analytic memos were written to capture initial impressions, recurring concerns, and emerging questions.

Open coding was conducted manually on printed transcripts using a line-by-line approach. Meaningful segments were highlighted and assigned descriptive labels. In vivo codes were prioritized wherever possible to preserve participants' language (e.g., "I'm scared of making mistakes," "drama makes me brave," "we just memorize and perform"). Each code was recorded in a coding log with a unique alphanumeric identifier (e.g., P3-O7 for Participant 3, Open code 7), enabling traceability and systematic comparison across transcripts.

Axial coding followed, during which conceptually related open codes were clustered into higher-order categories. For example, codes such as "afraid of judgment," "nervous to speak," and "shy in front of class" were grouped under the category *psychological and affective barriers*. Similarly, "teacher talks most of the time," "only scripted dialogues," and "no real conversation" were clustered as *limited opportunities for authentic interaction*. Constant comparison across all participants and particularly among the six focal participants allowed us to examine convergences and divergences in how similar classroom conditions were interpreted.

Through selective coding, these categories were refined into four interrelated themes: (1) psychological and affective barriers, (2) limited opportunities for authentic interaction, (3) assessment as performance, and (4) desired pedagogical shifts. Negative and deviant cases were actively sought to avoid premature closure. Throughout the process, analytic memos documented coding decisions, theoretical connections, and reflexive considerations. Peer debriefing with experienced qualitative researchers further enhanced analytic rigor and credibility. The final analysis emphasized how drama-mediated tasks intersected with systemic constraints to shape students' communicative engagement.

Findings

Psychological and affective barriers

To deepen understanding of how drama-based speaking shaped learner engagement, this theme draws together individual accounts that illuminate the affective terrain of the classroom. While the selected focal participants provide vivid entry points into learners' emotions, their experiences resonate with patterns evident across the broader cohort. The analysis underscores that psychological responses were neither uniform nor incidental, but dynamically shaped by students' perceived competence, classroom positioning, and the interactional demands placed upon them.

The interview excerpts reveal strong psychological and affective barriers that constrain students' speaking performance. A dominant theme is anxiety, manifested through physical reactions (e.g., racing heart, blank mind, forgetting words) and fear of negative evaluation, especially peer laughter or teacher correction. Many

participants rely on memorization, which provides a sense of safety but limits spontaneity and authentic communication. This dependence suggests that current classroom practices emphasize accuracy and performance over meaning-making. Several students also describe speaking tests as artificial, likening them to scripted performances rather than real conversations, which reduces confidence and engagement. Concerns about accent, limited vocabulary, and slow response time further heighten self-consciousness and disrupt focus. However, students express positive attitudes toward more interactive approaches, such as role-play, self-chosen topics, and video recordings, which they perceive as supportive of natural speech and self-improvement. Overall, the data indicate a need for low-anxiety, communicative, and learner-centered speaking environments.

Limited opportunities for authentic interaction

To illustrate how classroom structures shaped interactional possibilities, this theme draws on focal participant accounts alongside broader cohort patterns. Whereas curricular discourse promotes communicative engagement, students’ experiences suggest that interactional space was tightly regulated and unevenly distributed. The data reveal how scripted routines, evaluative questioning, and teacher-controlled turn-taking curtailed opportunities for genuine dialogue. At the same time, isolated improvisational moments briefly expanded learners’ communicative agency, underscoring both the promise and the fragility of drama-based opportunities within prevailing instructional constraints.

The data in Table 3 highlight students’ perceptions of limited authentic interaction in speaking activities. Many participants describe classroom speaking tasks as scripted, performance-oriented, and unnatural, which restricts genuine communication. Reliance on memorization provides short-term confidence but reduces opportunities for spontaneous language use and real-time thinking. This over-structured approach contributes to anxiety, hesitation, and difficulty responding in real conversations.

Table 3 Student quotes on limited authentic interaction

Participant	Code	Date	Response
FR (S6)	S6	Feb 2024	Not much, because we always follow the script. I can say the lines, but in real conversation I cannot respond fast. I also worry about my accent. Sometimes I think it's weird and then I lose focus
MR (S5)	S5	Feb 2024	Speaking test feels not natural... like we are performing, not talking. We prepare like a speech and then teacher corrects our mistakes. Role-play is more fun, but not many times we do it
I (S23)	S23	Feb 2024	Sometimes I know the idea, but I'm too nervous to speak. My heart beat fast, I forget words. And because not many spontaneous activities, I'm not used to it. I only feel better after some role-play, but it's not often
KA (S4)	S4	Feb 2024	Usually we just memorize the dialogue, so I feel safe. But when we must make our own sentences, I don't know what to say next. It's scary but new for me
D (S13)	S13	Feb 2024	In improvisation I feel like I'm really communicating, not just repeat. I need to think fast and listen carefully to my friends. It's more like real life. It's hard at first but also fun because we make our own story
NR (S21)	S21	Feb 2024	I like speaking, but sometimes I stop because I don't have enough vocabulary. If we can choose our own topic, maybe I can speak more naturally. I also think video recording can help. If I can see myself, I can improve, not just get the score

Source: Authors’ own work

Students also report affective barriers such as fear of making mistakes, worrying about accents, forgetting words, and losing focus, which further inhibit natural speech. In contrast, more open-ended activities—such as improvisation, role-play, and creating personal stories—are viewed as more meaningful and communicative, despite being initially challenging. These tasks require active listening, quick thinking, and peer interaction, which students associate with real-life communication. Additionally, learners value autonomy (e.g., choosing topics) and reflective tools like video recording, which they believe support improvement beyond test scores. Overall, the findings emphasize the importance of authentic, low-pressure speaking environments.

Assessment as performance

In examining how assessment practices shaped students' engagement with drama-based speaking, this theme foregrounds the tension between instructional intentions and evaluative realities. The interview data suggest that assessment served less as a scaffold for communicative growth and more as a culminating display of memorized output. By tracing how students negotiated these expectations, the findings reveal how product-focused assessment constrained risk-taking, reinforced accuracy-oriented norms, and mediated learners' confidence, participation, and willingness to experiment with language.

The data in Table 4 indicate that learners perceive speaking assessments primarily as performances rather than opportunities for meaningful communication. Many students describe tests as unnatural, scripted, and stage-like, which heightens anxiety and reduces spontaneity. The emphasis on memorization and one-time performances encourages surface-level preparation instead of genuine language use. Several participants note that feedback focuses mainly on mistakes and scores, offering little guidance on how to improve, which limits learning value. This score-oriented approach increases nervousness and shifts attention from communicative competence to error avoidance. Students also feel that assessments prioritize delivery over interactional skills, reinforcing the idea that speaking is about performing correctly rather than

Table 4 Learners' perceptions of assessment as performance

Participant	Code	Date	Response
MR (S5)	S5	Feb 2024	Speaking test feels not natural... like we are performing, not talking. We prepare like a speech and then teacher corrects our mistakes. Role-play is more fun, but not many times we do it
FR (S6)	S6	Feb 2024	When we have speaking tests, we just memorize. It's like a speech competition. The teacher gives a score after we talk, but we don't really learn how to talk naturally
KA (S4)	S4	Feb 2024	I only get feedback on mistakes, not on how to improve. So after the test, I just know I did wrong, but I don't know what to do next time
Z (S8)	S8	Feb 2024	We are assessed on delivery, but not interaction skills. Sometimes, I think the test is more about performance than communication
NR (S21)	S21	Feb 2024	I like speaking, but if the score is only from a big performance, it makes me nervous. If we can have more feedback or see our recording, maybe I can learn better
I (S23)	S23	Feb 2024	I feel nervous because the test is like performing on a stage. I forget words and then lose confidence. It's not like real conversation

Source: Authors' own work

engaging in real conversation. However, learners express a desire for more formative and reflective practices, such as detailed feedback and video recordings, which they believe could support self-awareness and gradual improvement. Overall, the findings suggest that current assessment practices may undermine confidence and communicative development, highlighting the need for more authentic, process-oriented evaluation methods.

Aspirations for pedagogical transformation

This final theme shifts from documenting challenges to foregrounding learners’ future-oriented perspectives on how drama-based speaking might be more meaningfully enacted. Rather than passive acceptance of existing practices, students articulated concrete suggestions that reveal a sophisticated awareness of what supports communicative development. Their aspirations illuminate a pedagogical imagination that centres interaction, collaboration, and formative feedback, highlighting the potential of drama to become a sustained vehicle for confidence-building, meaningful expression, and student ownership within EFL speaking classrooms.

The data in Table 5 reflect learners’ strong aspirations for more supportive, engaging, and communicative speaking practices. Students emphasize the value of drama-based activities, role-play, and improvisation, which they associate with enjoyment, reduced anxiety, and more authentic language use. These activities allow learners to interact meaningfully rather than perform for evaluation. Many participants also highlight the importance of autonomy, particularly in choosing their own topics, which they believe would increase motivation and help them speak more naturally. Small-group or pair work is viewed as less threatening than whole-class presentations, creating a safer environment for practice. Additionally, learners express a clear need for constructive, formative feedback that goes beyond scores and simple judgments, enabling them to understand how to improve. Although some students acknowledge that spontaneous speaking is initially difficult, they believe consistent practice can build confidence. Overall, the findings suggest that learners favor interactive, low-pressure, and learner-centered approaches to speaking development.

Table 5 Aspirational suggestions for future pedagogical improvements

Participant	Code	Date	Response
D (S13)	S13	Feb 2024	More drama-based activities make learning fun. I feel less nervous when I can act with friends and make stories together. It's not like a test
NR (S21)	S21	Feb 2024	I think if we can choose our own topic, we can speak more naturally. Sometimes the topic is boring or too difficult. If we can decide, maybe I can talk more
HN (S10)	S10	Feb 2024	I want more feedback on how to improve, not just scores. Sometimes I don't understand what the teacher means when they only say 'good' or 'wrong.'
KA (S4)	S4	Feb 2024	More spontaneous activities can help us to be brave. If we practice like this more, maybe I won't feel nervous when suddenly asked to speak
FR (S6)	S6	Feb 2024	I feel better in small groups or pairs. I can talk more, not just wait for my turn. It's more comfortable to speak with friends first before presenting
I (S23)	S23	Feb 2024	If there are more role-plays and improvisation, we can learn to speak without memorizing. It's hard at first, but I think it helps

Source: Authors’ own work

Discussion

Our findings demonstrate that psychological and affective constraints constitute a significant dimension of learners' experiences in drama-based speaking; however, these constraints were not distributed evenly across participants. Rather than functioning as uniform barriers, anxiety, inhibition, and communicative discomfort were mediated by learners' demographic and experiential profiles, such as language proficiency, willingness to communicate (WTC), and gendered participation patterns. This finding responds to calls for learner-sensitive interpretations of instructional practice, which caution against treating affective variables as universal or static (Dewaele et al., 2017). Lower-proficiency students with low WTC, exemplified by participants such as S4 and S23, tended to experience anxiety as immobilizing, especially in contexts requiring improvisation, spontaneous turn-taking, or public evaluation. Their narratives emphasized fear of negative judgment, cognitive shutdown, and somatic symptoms, suggesting a fragile sense of linguistic legitimacy. These learners appeared to occupy more vulnerable interactional positions, where speaking was perceived as risky rather than exploratory.

In contrast, higher-proficiency learners (e.g., S21) did not primarily describe anxiety but expressed frustration with restricted opportunities for self-expression. Their concerns were less about fear of failure and more about unmet communicative potential. This distinction is important, as it indicates that affective barriers are not simply a function of individual confidence, but are shaped by how learners are positioned within classroom participation structures. While lower-proficiency learners experienced drama-based speaking as threatening, higher-proficiency learners perceived it as underutilized. These contrasting responses illustrate that affective barriers emerge through the intersection of perceived capability, pedagogic expectations, and interactional access. Gendered participation patterns further complicated these dynamics: female students, particularly those with lower WTC, tended to report heightened sensitivity to peer evaluation and public exposure, echoing research suggesting that classroom speaking anxiety is often socially indexed and relational rather than purely cognitive (Mercer, 2019). This empirical evidence reinforces the view that foreign language anxiety is dynamic, situationally triggered, and socially mediated rather than a stable individual trait (Dewaele et al., 2017).

The prominence of teacher-led evaluation and corrective feedback further intensified affective filtering, functioning as an "interactional gatekeeper" that regulated who could safely participate and under what conditions (Atkinson, 2011). While drama-based activities were designed to expand expressive space, they paradoxically surfaced latent anxieties embedded in longstanding performative traditions. This tension was not experienced equally: students with lower WTC interpreted public speaking as exposure, whereas those with higher WTC interpreted it as opportunity. These differentiated responses underscore the need to conceptualize affect not merely as a personal variable but as an outcome of structural positioning within classroom ecologies.

A second salient theme concerns the limited opportunities for meaningful, spontaneous communication within speaking lessons, despite curricular commitments to communicative competence. Classroom activities remained dominated by scripted dialogues, teacher-fronted questioning, and rehearsed role-plays. For many participants, drama tasks were episodic rather than sustained pedagogical practices. Importantly,

these limitations were experienced differently depending on learners' readiness and communicative orientation. Lower-intermediate students often found improvisation overwhelming due to the absence of linguistic scaffolding, while higher-proficiency learners perceived scripted work as restrictive and demotivating. This divergence illustrates how a single pedagogical structure can simultaneously constrain one group while under-challenging another.

Authentic interaction defined as contingent, co-constructed, and learner-generated language was rare and unevenly distributed (Kaneyasu, 2025). For lower-WTC learners, this scarcity reinforced affective barriers by limiting opportunities to habituate spontaneous speech in low-risk environments. Meanwhile, higher-WTC learners expressed frustration at the infrequency of activities that allowed for communicative agency (S13, S21). Although episodes of collaborative storytelling and improvisation briefly disrupted hierarchical talk patterns, these moments were not systematized. Without differentiated scaffolding, gradual sequencing, and redistribution of interactional rights, such practices remained incidental. From a socio-cognitive perspective, interactional competence develops through sustained participation and guided risk-taking (Moorhouse et al., 2021); in this case, structural constraints disproportionately disadvantaged those least prepared to assume communicative risk.

The third theme highlights learners' perception that speaking assessment positioned communication as a polished performance rather than a developmental process. Students described oral tests as emphasizing memorization, delivery, and accuracy, with minimal attention to interactional responsiveness or spontaneous meaning-making. However, this perception was not uniform. For lower-proficiency and low-WTC learners (e.g., S4, S23), high-stakes assessment amplified anxiety and reinforced avoidance behaviors. For others (e.g., S21), performance-based assessment was not inherently problematic but became demotivating due to the absence of formative feedback and reflective opportunities. This contrast illustrates how identical assessment formats can function as either motivational or exclusionary mechanisms depending on learners' affective positioning.

These findings align with research showing that EFL speaking assessments often privilege form over function, thereby discouraging risk-taking and communicative experimentation (Isaacs & Harding, 2022; May et al., 2023). The dominance of summative, teacher-centered evaluation reinforced a monologic model of communication that contradicted the dialogic aims of drama pedagogy (Walsh & Matsumura, 2025). Students were encouraged to "communicate" during instruction but evaluated on rehearsed output, creating a systemic contradiction that particularly disadvantaged learners with fragile linguistic identities. Thus, assessment emerges not merely as a technical tool but as a site of affective stratification.

Despite these constraints, learners articulated aspirational visions for more equitable, supportive, and learner-centered pedagogies. Students across profiles called for greater use of improvisation, collaborative work, topic choice, and scaffolded feedback. However, their motivations differed: lower-WTC learners emphasized emotional safety and gradual exposure, while higher-WTC learners sought increased autonomy and challenge. This distinction is crucial, as it suggests that learner-centered pedagogy must be differentiated rather than uniformly applied.

Drama was valued not as theatrical display but as a medium for relational engagement, confidence-building, and identity negotiation. Calls for formative feedback, peer collaboration, and video reflection reflect a desire for assessment as learning rather than assessment of learning (Carless & Winstone, 2023). These aspirations highlight a systemic misalignment between pedagogical intentions and classroom realities (Bicer et al., 2025). Crucially, students positioned themselves not as passive recipients of instruction but as agentive participants capable of articulating the conditions necessary for meaningful engagement.

Conclusion

This study examined Indonesian EFL university students' perceptions of drama-based speaking pedagogy and the challenges they faced within existing instructional and assessment structures. Interview findings revealed a complex interplay of psychological, structural, and pedagogical factors shaping participation. Students frequently reported affective barriers, such as anxiety, nervousness, and fear of negative evaluation in improvisational tasks. These emotions were linked to prior experiences with teacher-centered, accuracy-focused instruction that emphasized memorization and error correction. Structural constraints such as teacher-fronted interaction, limited improvisation, and product-oriented assessments further reinforced reliance on scripted speech and discouraged risk-taking. Despite these obstacles, students valued interactive, learner-centered approaches, including improvisation, peer collaboration, and constructive feedback. They envisioned assessments that supported reflection and communicative growth rather than error correction alone. Overall, the study highlights both the potential and challenges of drama-based pedagogy, underscoring the need for interaction-focused, feedback-rich, and emotionally supportive practices that foster genuine communicative competence.

Practical implications

This study highlights key implications for EFL teacher education, curriculum design, and practice. Drama-based pedagogy should be framed not as performance but as a scaffolded pathway to communicative development, using role-play, improvisation, and storytelling to guide learners from scripted practice toward authentic interaction. Creating psychologically safe spaces is essential, enabling students to rehearse, experiment, and err without fear of judgment. Small-group rehearsals, collaborative tasks, and low-stakes activities can reduce anxiety and build confidence before formal assessments. Assessment practices should also shift from summative, accuracy-based testing to formative, dialogic approaches that include peer/self-assessment, reflection, and video review. Feedback should function as collaborative dialogue, fostering metacognitive awareness and agency. Institutional support is critical: drama pedagogy must be integrated into curricula, aligned with learning outcomes, and supported by teacher training in socio-cognitive and feedback-oriented methods. Broadly, drama-based approaches can enrich communicative environments and better prepare learners for real-world language use.

Study weaknesses

This study offers valuable insights into students' psychological experiences and classroom dynamics in drama-based speaking activities, but several limitations should be noted. The findings rely largely on qualitative interview data, which may be affected by self-reporting bias or students' limited awareness of their cognitive and emotional processes. The small sample of EFL university students from a single institution also restricts the transferability of results to other contexts with different pedagogical or cultural conditions. Moreover, the absence of triangulation with complementary data, such as classroom observations, recorded performances, or quantitative measures limits the objectivity and depth of analysis. The short, one-semester data collection period further prevents exploration of longitudinal changes in affective development or communicative competence. Variations in student engagement may also have influenced data quality, particularly regarding spontaneous interaction. Finally, the study focused on learners' perspectives, without incorporating teachers' views or discourse patterns that significantly shape classroom interaction.

Future studies

Future research could adopt mixed-methods approaches, combining interviews, classroom observations, video recordings, and discourse analysis to capture how affective, structural, and pedagogical factors intersect in drama-based speaking tasks. Longitudinal studies tracking students across semesters could reveal how affective barriers evolve and how sustained drama pedagogy impacts communicative competence. Expanding research across diverse institutions and cultural contexts would enhance transferability, while incorporating teacher and educator perspectives could illuminate co-constructed classroom norms and assessment practices. With digital technology increasingly central to language learning, studies could explore online or hybrid drama activities such as virtual role-plays, digital storytelling, and video-based self-assessment. Additionally, investigating emotional and relational dynamics: peer feedback, psychological safety, and identity negotiation through socio-cognitive or sociocultural lenses can deepen understanding of learners' communicative agency and resilience, ultimately informing more context-sensitive, theory-driven innovations in EFL drama pedagogy.

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Data Availability

No datasets were generated or analysed during the current study.

Declarations

Competing interests

The authors declare no competing interests.

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